

What might be called the Mozartian and Wagnerian sides of Strauss's musical personality also intermingle in most of his later operas. *Ariadne auf Naxos* (1912, revised 1916), is a chamber opera of self-conscious sophistication. Like *Rosenkavalier*, it contains three great soprano roles: the ardent, idealistic young composer (apparently modeled on the teenage Mozart), the death-haunted Ariadne, and the flighty coloratura soprano Zerbinetta. *Die Frau ohne Schatten* (*The Woman Without a Shadow*, 1913 ), a symbolic fairy tale that focuses on themes of human fertility and marital relationships, is Strauss's and Hofmannsthal's homage to *The Magic Flute*. Its orchestration is the most sumptuous and glittering in all of Strauss's oeuvre—which is saying something—while the Empress and the dyer Barak sing some of his most fervently lyrical music.

Inspiration burned more fitfully in Strauss's later operas, of which the two most successful are *Arabella* (1933), a comedy-cum-fairy-tale set in a faintly sleazy 1860s Vienna, and the urbane “conversation piece” *Capriccio* (1942). Essentially an opera about opera, this is Strauss's supreme act of Rococo-Romantic escapism amid the barbarism of war.